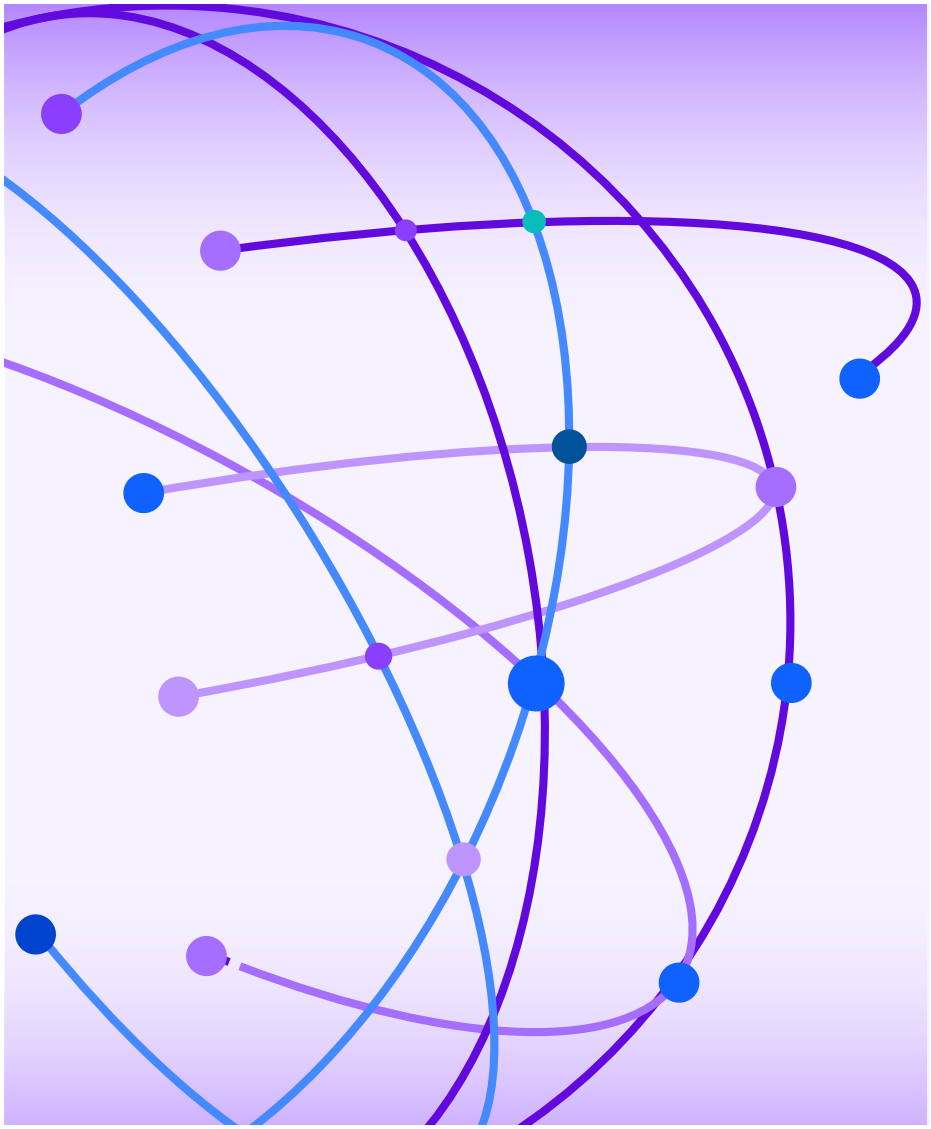
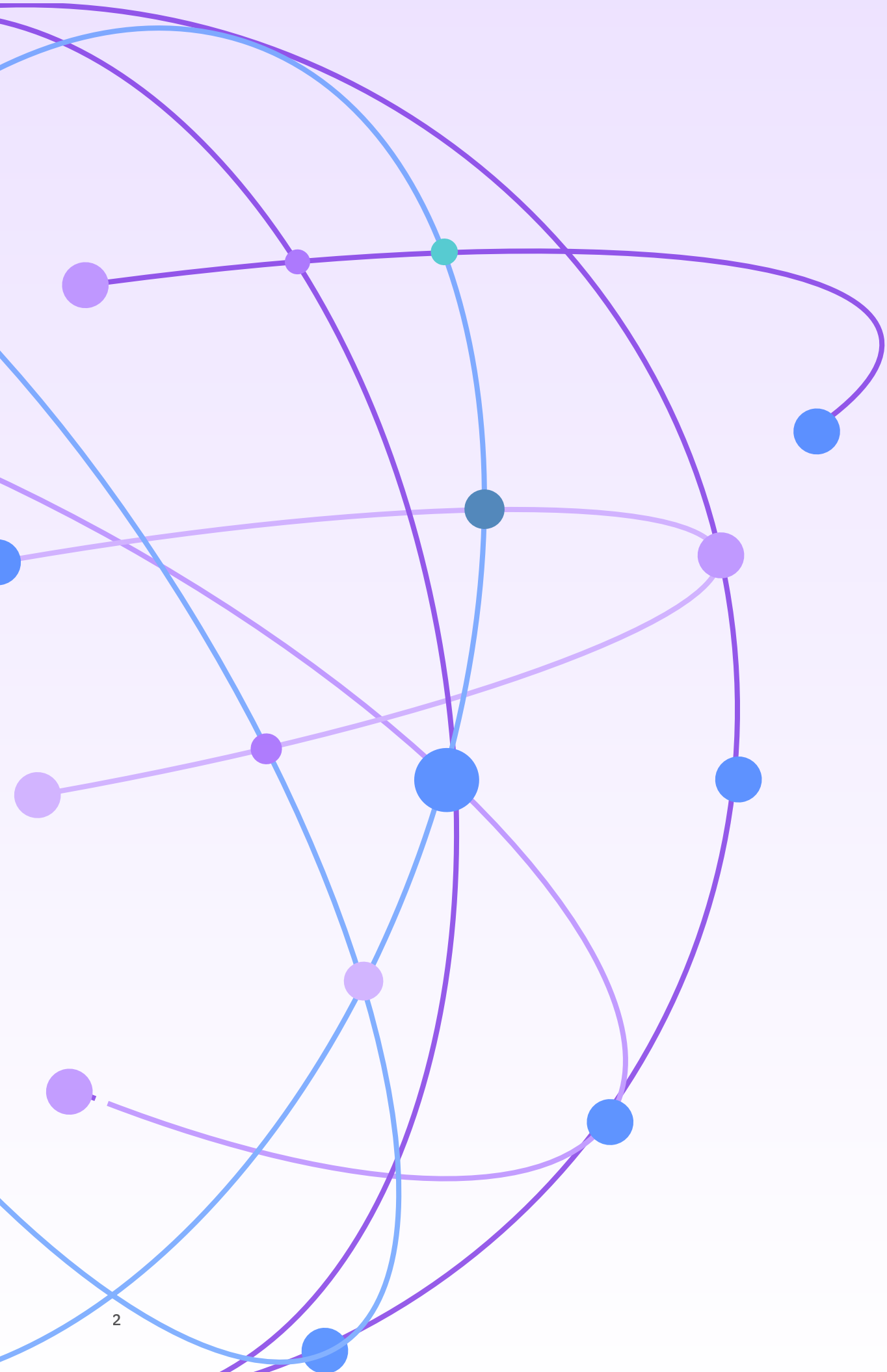


Corporate banking beyond the transaction

Value shifts toward intelligence

IBM | BIAN Banking Industry Architecture Network | BAFT



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Drawing on deep expertise in banking and marketing strategy, Diane explores how innovation, emerging technologies, and market disruption are reshaping financial services. Her executive-level research helps leaders anticipate change, identify growth opportunities, and navigate transformation. Diane has co-authored influential publications that inform senior decision-making and contribute to global thought leadership across banking and financial markets.

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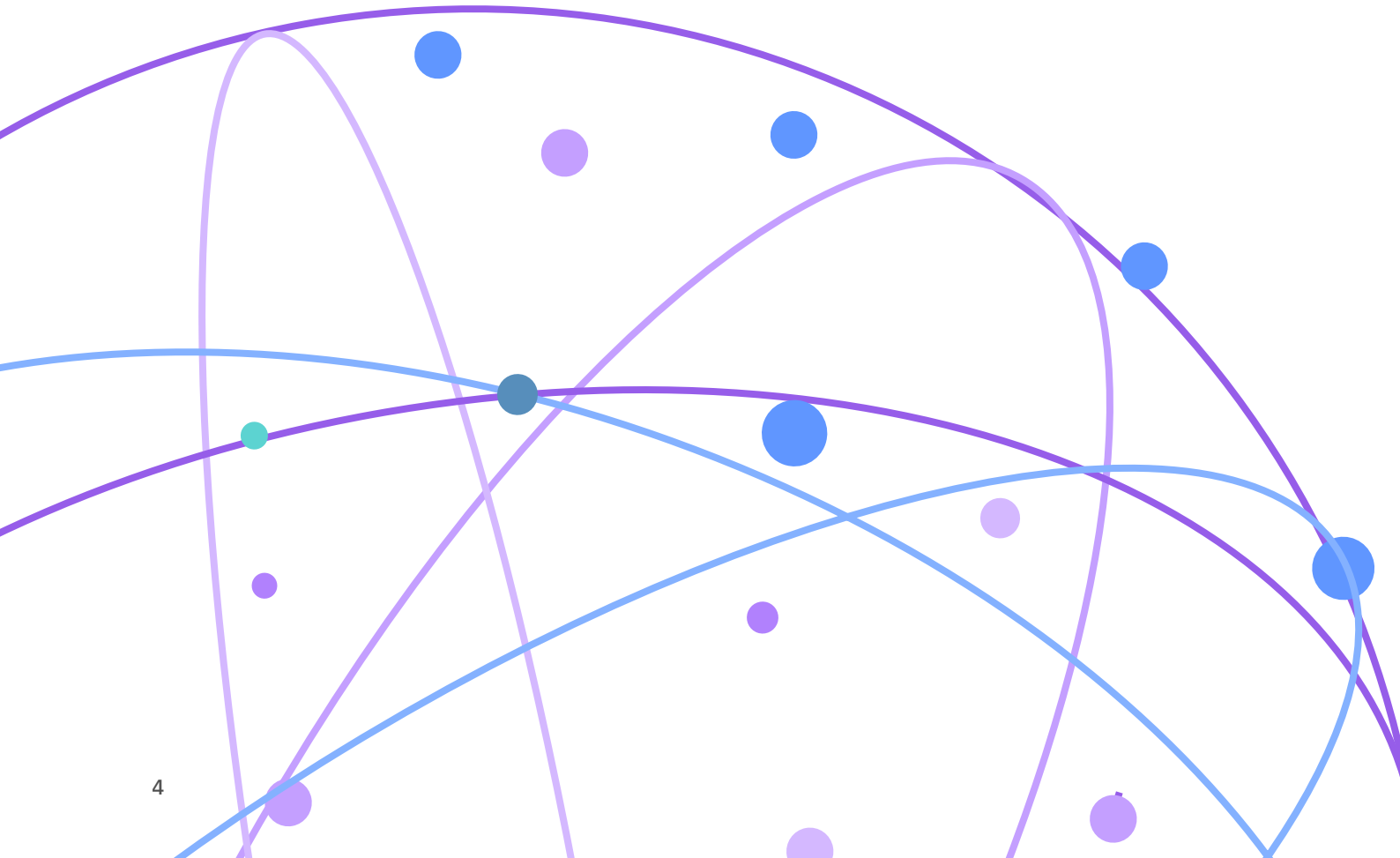
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Reimagine a bank's role

Just as consumers demand intuitive access to payments and services through mobile apps and digital platforms—without waiting for a branch or call center—CFOs and treasurers of corporations increasingly insist on equivalent speed, personalization, and control in their banking. Fragmented processes, delayed information, and purely in-person interactions no longer meet the standard.

This redesign is being accelerated by AI, tokenization, and platform-based orchestration, which are opening new avenues for corporate clients to consume financial services. The engagement model is evolving rapidly—from traditional direct banking relationships, through self-directed embedded platform services, to agentic AI that enables banking clients to self-orchestrate the discovery, selection, and execution of financial solutions in real time.

Clients remain committed to trusted relationships, which is the backbone of banking. Yet they now expect those relationships to be embedded within the digital workflows and autonomous systems that drive their day-to-day business performance.

For banking executives, the strategic choice is clear. One path uses technology merely to make today's operating models faster and less expensive. The more ambitious path deploys innovation to reimagine the bank's role—becoming the intelligent orchestration layer that helps clients anticipate disruption, unlock working capital, manage risk dynamically, and compete with greater confidence.

Whichever path executives take, the application of industry standards is advantageous to streamline architectural decisions that connect business and technology intentionality in a single voice.

This study examines that strategic choice from the perspective of both banks and their clients. It shows how diverse industries are rethinking banking engagement models; why proactive, always-on advisory support is becoming a source of differentiation; and how tokenization can improve efficiency while challenging established profit pools. It also explores why many banks may still be underestimating AI's potential to create new revenue models—or even to disintermediate traditional relationships by empowering CFOs and treasurers. Our research also provides practical actions that can enhance the strategic position of any financial service provider.

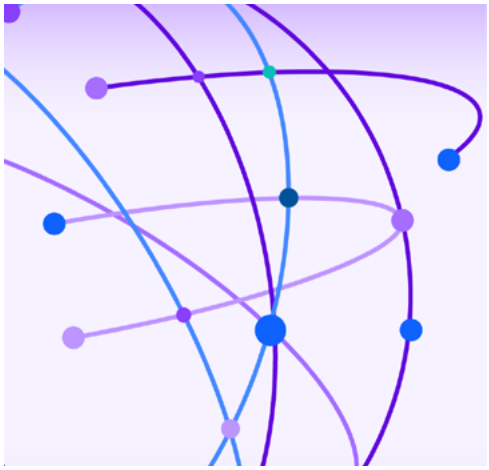
We encourage you to view this report as the start of a conversation about what corporate banking is becoming next. Consider where your institution is still constrained by fragmentation, incremental modernization, or legacy ways of working. Then ask how you can take the first meaningful steps toward the future—with clients, partners, technology teams, and your organization.

Tod Burwell

President and CEO
BAFT (Bankers Association for Finance and Trade)

Steve C. Van Wyk

Chairman of the Board
BIAN (Banking Industry Architecture Network)



Key takeaways

Bankers must position themselves as trusted partners in intelligence, risk, and execution.

- **Corporate banking clients expect greater control.**

  57% are moving toward self-directed models like platform-first engagement and dynamic, AI-driven orchestration of product and service consumption.

- **Proactive 24/7 support is the top client demand.**

  Banks will need AI-powered customer services to deliver it.

- **Profit pools and revenue streams are shifting.**

  72% of bankers expect stablecoins to boost efficiency, while 75% of clients expect to pay less for transactions. Whether that efficiency accrues to the bank or is challenged by fee compression depends on how the bank defines its role in the tokenized ecosystem.

- **Bankers are underleveraging AI.**

  Fewer than 20% see revenue as the primary outcome, instead focusing on efficiency gains.

Introduction

Reinvention in a fragmented world

Today corporate bankers must defend their relevance in new ways, as increasingly sophisticated corporate treasuries leverage rapid technological change. Industry CFOs and treasurers need faster liquidity, more transparent risk management, and seamless orchestration across borders and counterparties. They see AI as an opportunity to dynamically select the optimal mix of financial products and services for the lowest price. Many are inclined to self-direct on digital platforms that bundle multiple financial providers.

This is nothing less than a paradigm shift. As transactions become commoditized, bankers need to reinvent their role. They must integrate AI and tokenization into their business models, positioning themselves as trusted partners in intelligence, risk, and execution directly embedded in client workflows.

Two research surveys from the IBM Institute for Business Value (IBV)—one with corporate CFOs and treasurers, the other with senior banking executives—reveal how corporate banks and their clients are navigating rapid change. The analysis was conducted in partnership with BAFT (Bankers Association for Finance and Trade) and BIAN (Banking Industry Architecture Network), tapping 500 global CFOs and treasurers across multiple industries, and 250 corporate bankers at institutions globally. We also conducted eight in-depth interviews with bank executives to gather qualitative insights that inform our analysis.[1]

This study therefore serves as both a mirror and a roadmap detailing key challenges and how banks can address them. In Part One, we explore how industry CFOs and treasurers are rethinking their banking needs and priorities. Part Two delves into where banks are today and their options for adjustment. Part Three presents an Action Guide to help the strategic position of any financial service provider. The banks that thrive won't tinker around the edges of their revenue model. They'll embrace entirely new ways of engaging with clients to become their strategic advisors and embedded partners, rather than just digital facilitators of transactions.

Part one

At an inflection point

Corporate CFOs and treasurers are ready for new approaches that shift the control point away from banks.

More than half (54%) operate with a hybrid model that combines relationships with major banks and a niche set of financial specialists for defined needs (see Figure 1). These companies, almost half of which are global or international players, work with seven banks on average. Some maintain as many as 16 banking relationships (see Figure 5).

Such fragmentation is not accidental. It reflects the unique requirements of trade finance solutions, supply chain programs, and cash management across different regions. Yet this multi-bank reality also creates friction: duplicated processes and inconsistent data that slow decision-making. These are precisely the pain points that digital solutions can resolve.

In our survey, CFOs and treasurers say they expect today's hybrid model prevalence to halve. One in three say they plan to move toward dynamic orchestration in which AI empowers them to manage routing of payments, liquidity, treasury operations, and financing needs in near real time. Another 24% would prefer a platform-first ecosystem model in which multi-bank digital platforms become the core interface.

"I expect many of the most valuable innovations to emerge not from banks acting alone, but from ecosystems that bring together banks, technology providers, and corporate customers."

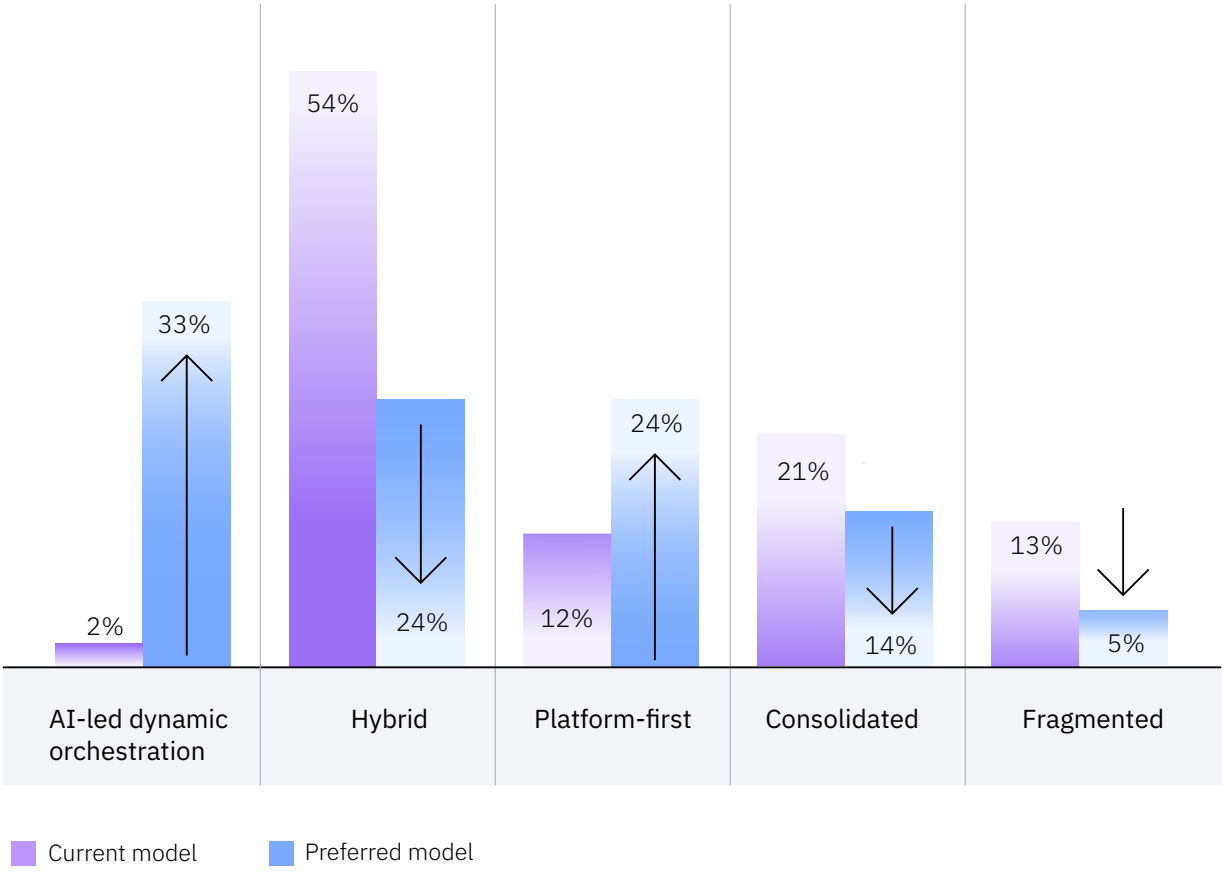
Aleem Shamji, Managing Director, Technology Banking, HSBC

"AI helps corporate treasury teams shift from managing information to acting on insights, moving from what happened yesterday to what may happen tomorrow."

Rachelle Hildyard, Managing Director, Global FIG and Correspondent Banking, Scotiabank

Figure 1

Ready for change: Corporate CFOs and treasurers want greater control of banking relationships



Perspective

Emerging models challenge banks to evolve

In the model most widely used today for corporate banking services, companies turn to a primary bank for the majority of their financial needs and engage specialists on an as-needed basis. Some firms, instead, work with a small number of relevant banks and integrate them tightly into their processes. Others operate in a more fragmented landscape, leaving banking selection to geographical and business-specific needs. However, our study points to an emerging preference for platform-first and dynamic orchestration models that de-center any single financial institution. These models allow corporate clients to use their own AI tools or multi-bank platforms to select and route services independently.

Traditional models

Hybrid

Corporate banking clients rely on a primary bank providing most needed services. They also reach out to specialists or local providers for differentiating services.

Consolidated

Corporate clients work with few core banks whose services are deeply and strategically integrated into their processes.

Fragmented

Corporate clients manage banking relationships in a decentralized manner, according to geographical needs or business activity.

Emerging models

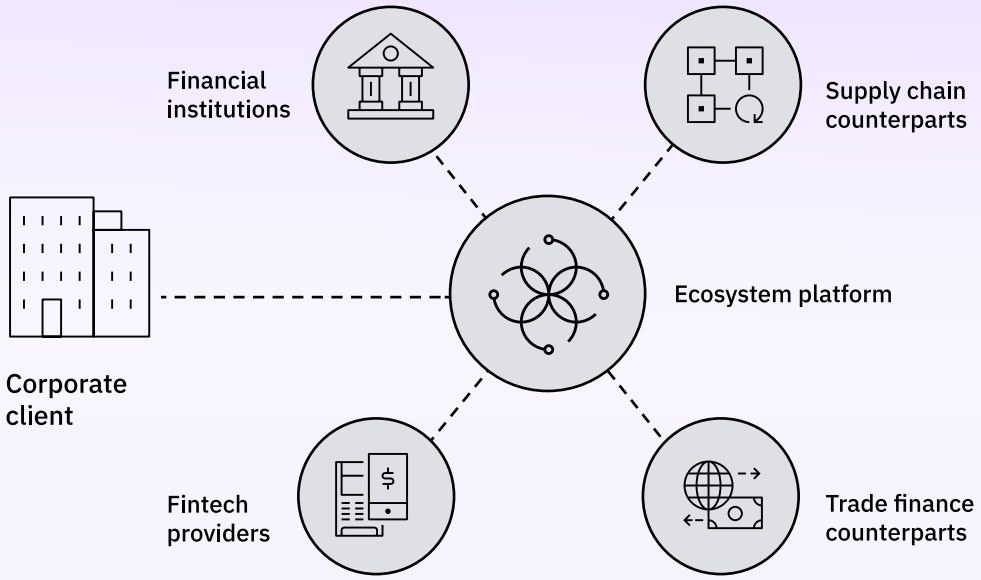
Platform-first

Corporate clients leverage third-party digital platforms that intermediate banks and embed multiple providers such as supply chain and trade finance counterparts.

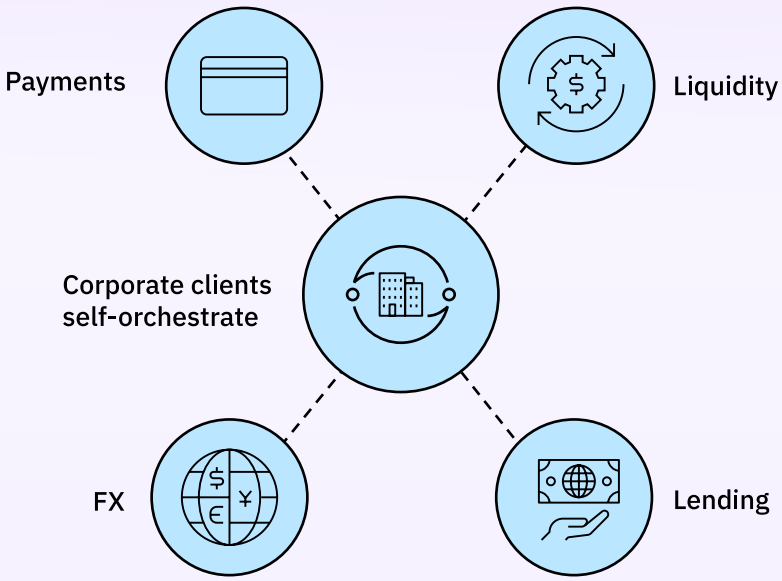
AI-led dynamic orchestration

Corporate clients leverage AI and agentic AI to orchestrate with great autonomy their access to financial products and solutions. They dynamically select the optimal providers for services like payments, liquidity, funding, or FX hedging.

Platform-first model



AI-led dynamic orchestration model



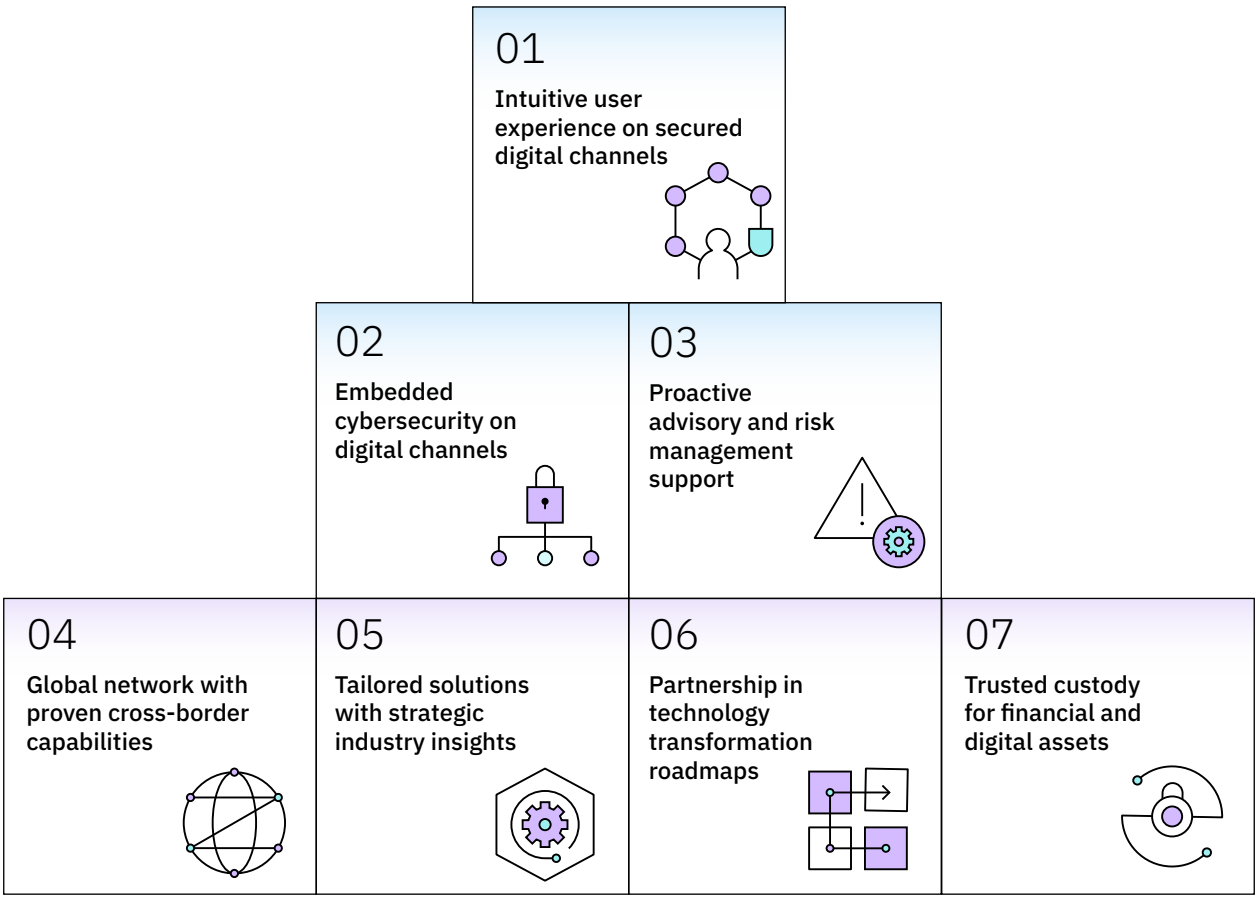
Convenience, advice, insights

Corporate CFOs and treasurers increasingly expect seamless consumer-grade convenience, intuitive user experiences and reduced complexity that deliver real-time visibility across secured digital channels—without extensive training or required workarounds.They are also looking for banks that provide timely advisory and proactive risk management insights (see Figure 2).

In trade finance and supply chain programs—where decisions frequently involve multiple banking counterparts and regulations—strategic advisory has become more critical than ever before. As cash flow forecasting has become significantly more difficult, there is growing demand for working capital modeling paired with 24/7 proactive client support (see Figure 3).

Figure 2

Most relevant factors influencing corporate clients' choice of primary banking relationships

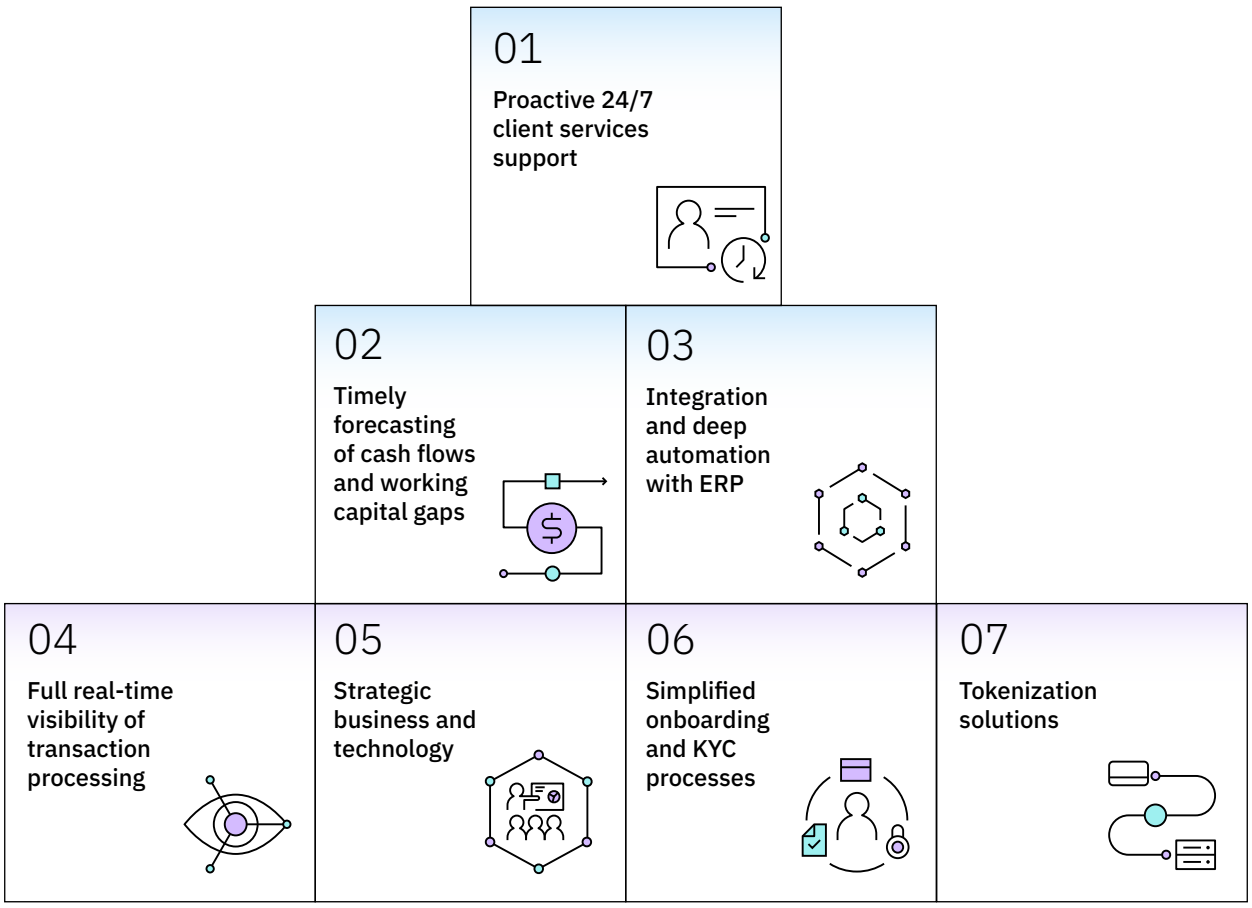


More than 70% of surveyed CFOs and treasurers rank scenario modeling and forecasting at the top of their investment priorities. By combining deep-tier data platforms with AI-driven analytics, companies can run dynamic "what-if" simulations, stress-test funding needs under various scenarios, and move from reactive cash management to proactive liquidity planning.

Traditional forecasting models often fall short because they rely on incomplete, delayed, or siloed data across complex supply chains. This makes it hard to anticipate sudden shifts in demand, payment timings, or supplier disruptions. Deep-tier supply chain finance solutions aggregate granular, real-time data from beyond direct (Tier 1) suppliers, providing previously invisible details on inventory positions and payment behaviors.

Figure 3

Top contributions of primary banks to the efficiency of corporate clients' finance and treasury operations



Tokenization and stablecoins

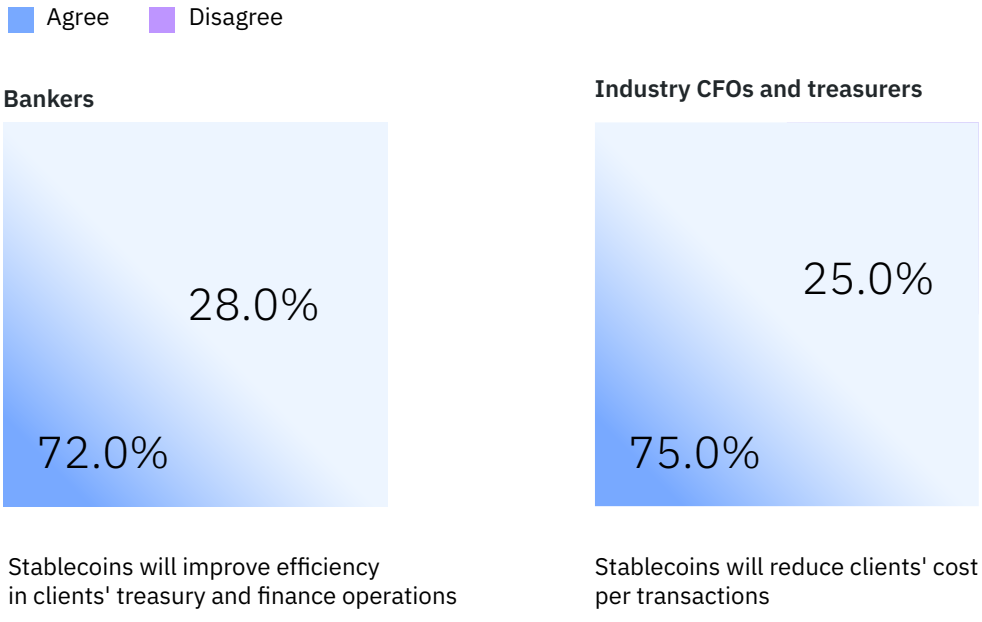
Corporate CFOs, treasurers, and banking executives are optimistic about the potential value of tokenization and payment stablecoins to boost efficiency and orchestrate trade and supply chain finance operations (see Figure 4 about stablecoins). But the two carry materially different consequences for the bank's balance sheet.

These are different propositions, and they pull the bank in different directions. Tokenizing assets—from receivables and invoices to trade instruments and warehouse receipts—changes how collateral and documentation move. It is largely additive to the franchise. A tokenized deposit changes the rail, not the money: the balance remains a liability of the issuing bank, available to fund lending and inside the regulatory perimeter the bank already manages. A stablecoin payment, on the other hand, is a claim on an issuer, backed by segregated reserves held outside the bank's funding base.

> "Tokenized deposits bring a concrete advantage for working capital: because the instrument is digital end-to-end, products can be issued far faster than through traditional channels."
>
> **Sridhar Somaraju,** Director of Transformation, Business Banking, Nationwide Building Society

Figure 4

Most bankers expect stablecoins to unlock efficiency gains—while most corporate clients expect lower transaction costs



Efficiency gained through tokenized assets and tokenized deposits accrues to the bank. Efficiency gained through a stablecoin payment can accrue to the client while the settlement balance—and the funding it represents—migrates elsewhere. For banks, finding the right posture is essential to building an economic model that scales.

With regard to fee-based revenue streams, IBM IBV research[2] on tokenization found that corporate bankers identify these top four opportunities, in order of preference: fast cross-border payments, liquidity and working capital, programmability, and custody. The defensive opportunity also carries value: issuing tokenized deposits to keep corporate settlement balances on the bank's own balance sheet while matching the 24/7 programmability clients are asking for. For most corporate banks, the deposit franchise is worth considerably more than the fee pool being considered as a replacement. To compete in the tokenized economy, banks must apply their core strengths—trust, regulatory expertise, and balance sheet capacity—to both halves of that response.

Corporate bankers' fee-based priorities with tokenization:

1. **Fast cross-border payments**
   Charging fees for tokenized, real-time cross-border transactions that bypass traditional correspondent banking delays and costs.
2. **Liquidity and working capital**
   Offering fee-based services that provide instant visibility of cash flows across supply chain flows.
3. **Programmability**
   Generating recurring fees from payment solutions that automate condition-based disbursements, invoice financing, and working capital management via smart contracts.
4. **Custody**
   Earning fees for holding tokenized assets and digital instruments—securities, trade documents, and collateral—on behalf of corporate clients, including the key management and control environment institutional clients require.

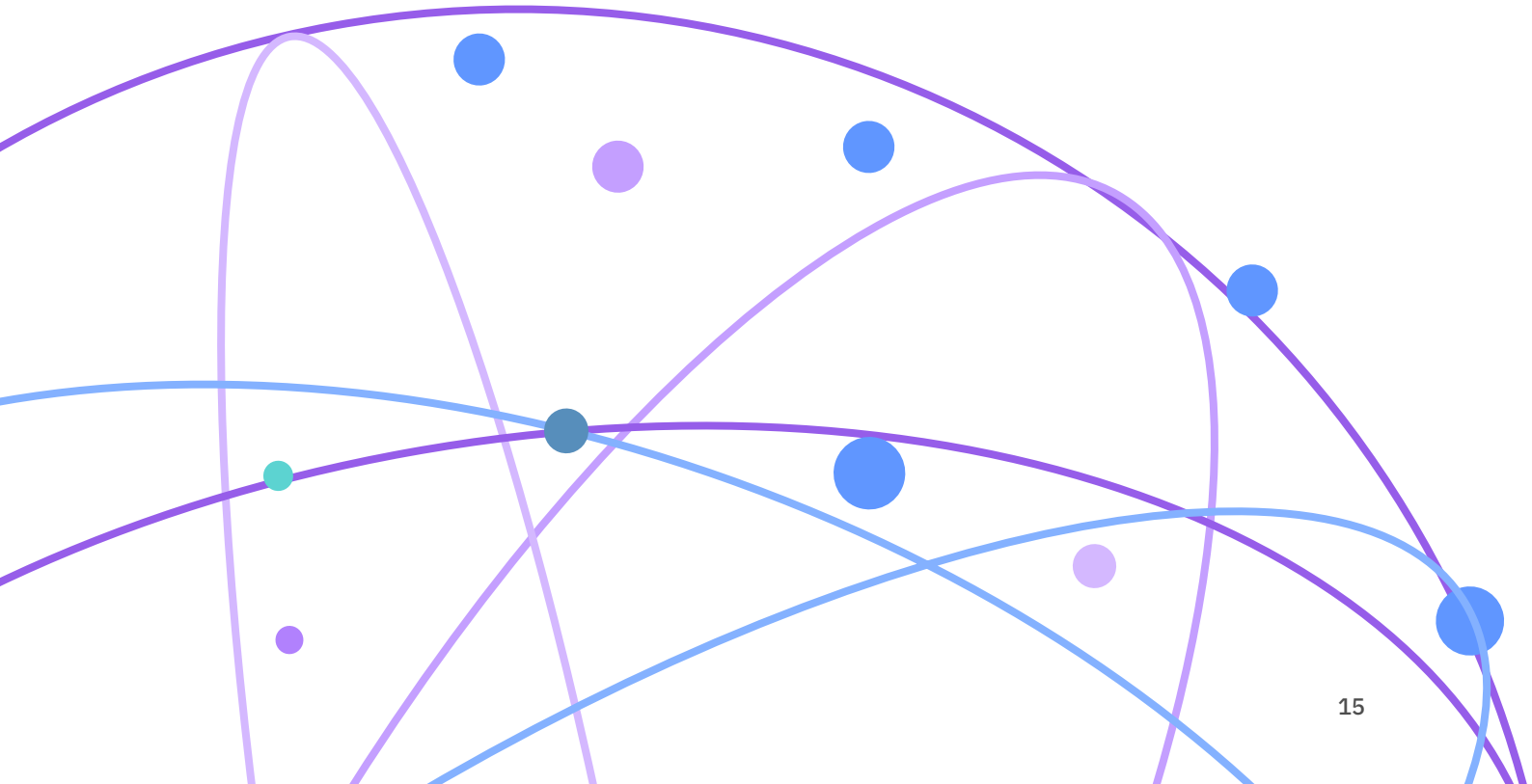


Figure 5

Percentage of corporate clients working with multiple banks

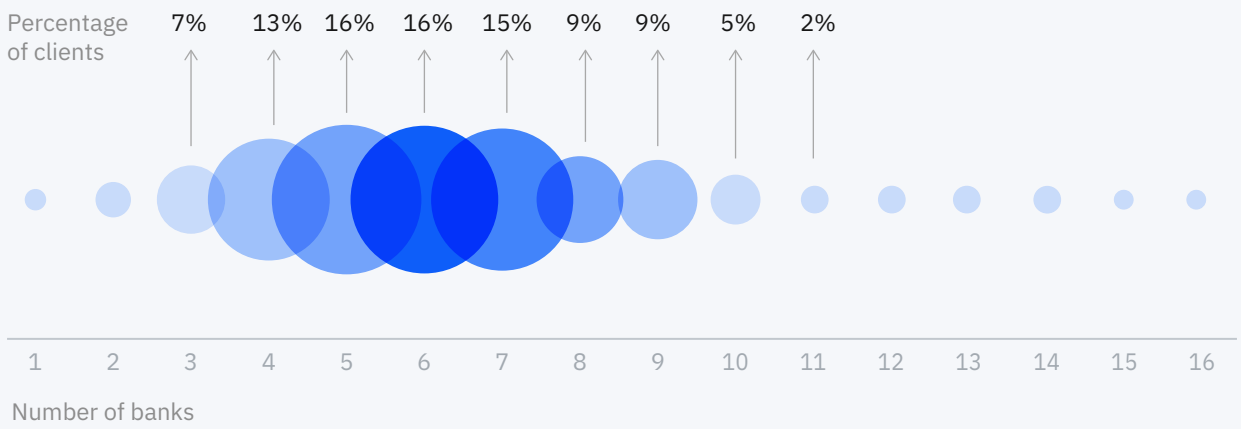


Figure 6

Distribution of corporate clients served per bank

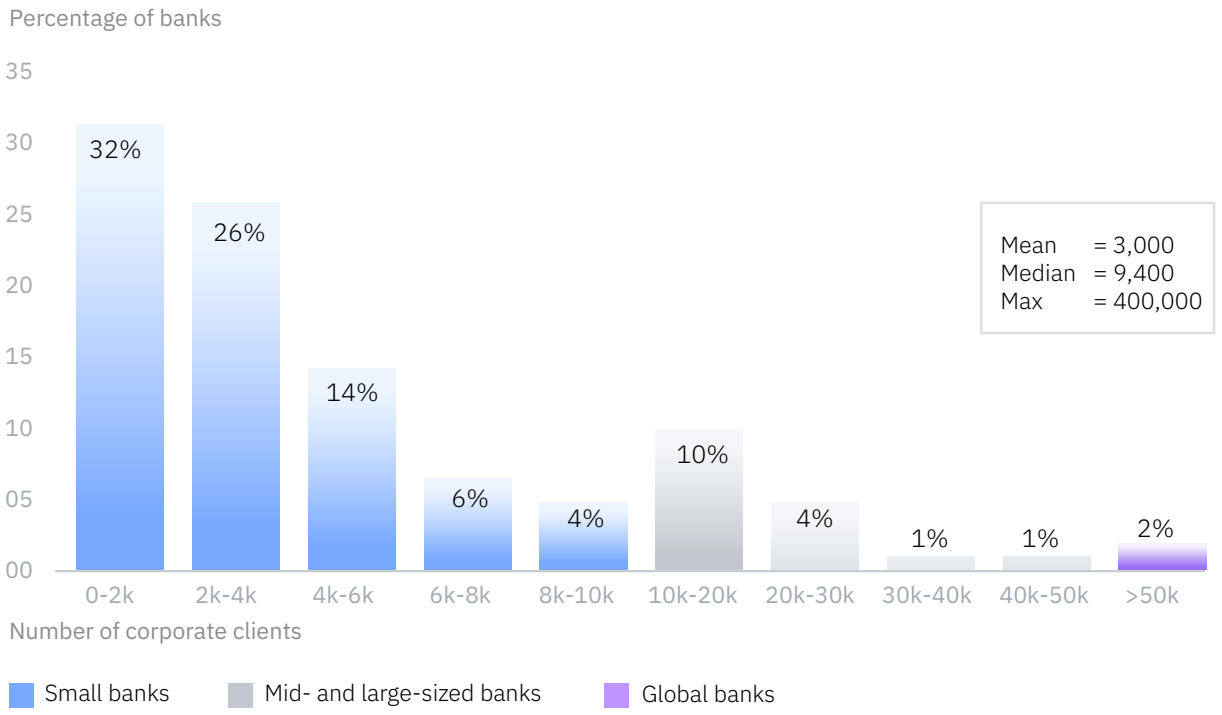


Figure 7

Most banks now allow corporate clients to self-direct via a digital platform

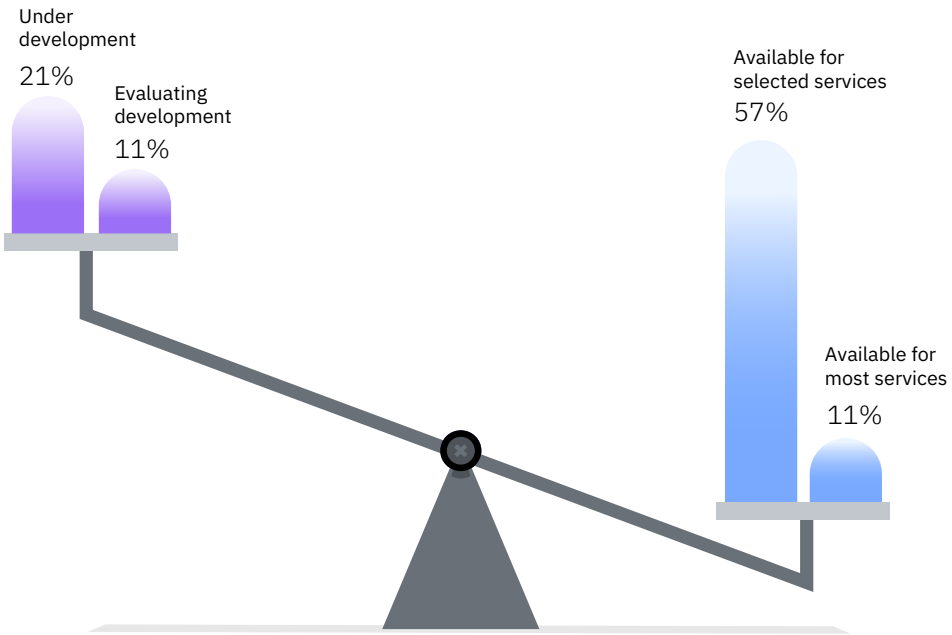
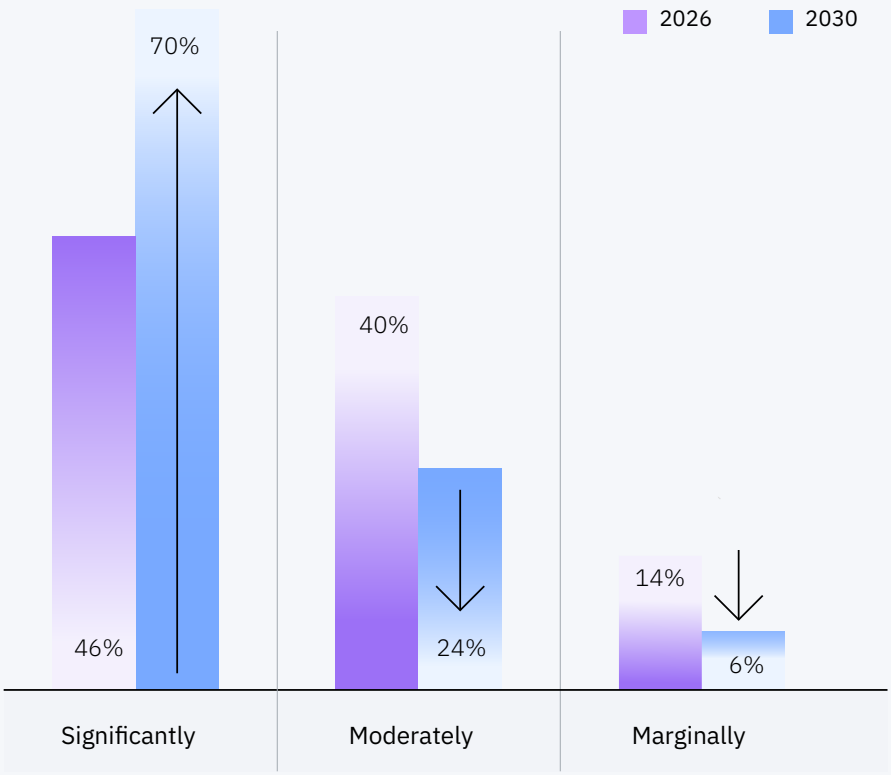


Figure 8

Corporate clients expect growing reliance on self-directed banking services via digital platforms



Part two

Beyond incremental change

Corporate banks are investing in technology to fuel change and reconcile any potential disconnects between what corporate clients increasingly want and how banks are servicing them now. Our research reveals a notable hesitation in bankers' scope and ambition with respect to AI.

The opportunity now at hand

The opportunity for banks mastering not only digital channels but also platform orchestration extends well beyond financing itself. Trade finance is executed within a dense web of operational complexity: document preparation and verification, customs compliance, sanctions screening, or insurance coordination across multiple jurisdictions. Banks that historically focused on providing only the financial instrument—the letter of credit, the guarantee, the receivables facility—left the surrounding operational burden entirely with their clients. This is particularly onerous for mid-market companies that lack the specialist headcount of large multinationals.

The most innovative fintech shifts have been fueled by the convergence of financial capabilities and adjacent operational services into a single integrated experience—think payroll processing and accounting, but also inventory management, or pre-validated import compliance. The result is a stickier relationship, higher perceived value, and a defensible margin structure that pure banking providers cannot replicate.

This bundled value proposition can transform the bank from a transactional counterparty into an embedded partner that justifies a fundamentally different conversation about pricing and relationship depth. The question for banking executives is not whether such service bundling opportunities exist, but how quickly they can build or partner to seize them before others do.

"The key question is not relationship versus digital—it is how to combine both. Digital enables scale and efficiency, but complex decisions still require trust and human interaction. The challenge is to deliver high-tech alongside high-touch."

Juliano Marcatto, Head of International Business, Banco do Brasil

Revenue generation

Banks are investing in AI—but caution becomes evident when they assess AI's transformative potential. Fewer than 20% view revenue generation as a primary outcome of AI adoption. The overwhelming emphasis remains on efficiency gains through automation, cost reduction, and improved risk management. This reflects a broader mindset among bankers: they are more comfortable using AI to do existing activities, faster and cheaper, than to create entirely new economic models in a heavily regulated environment.

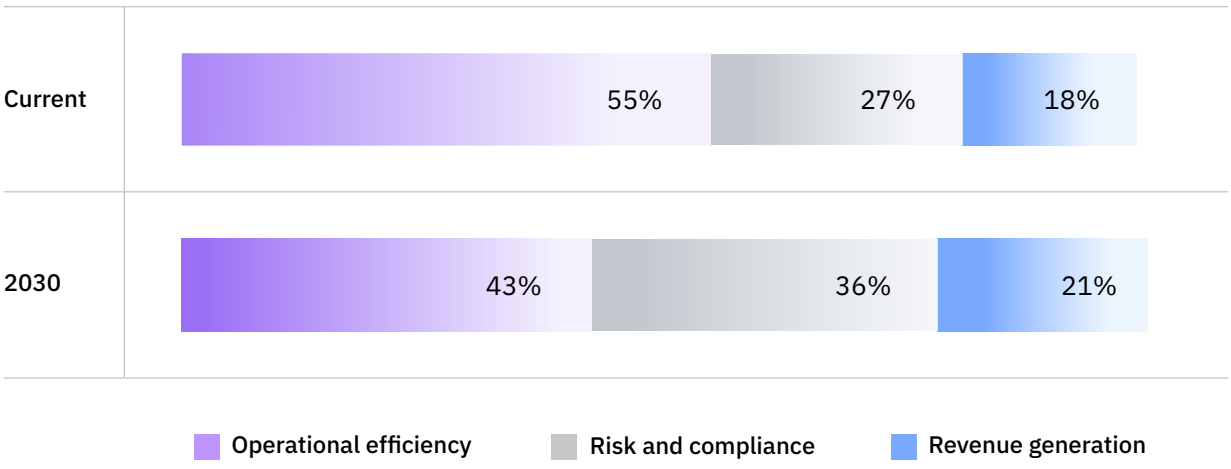
When bankers do consider revenue-related opportunities, their top priority is to improve relationship management and advisory services (42%). Many see AI as a powerful tool to deliver more proactive, data-driven advice to corporate clients. For example, flagging potential liquidity shortfalls or suggesting optimal hedging strategies before the client even raises the issue. About half expect AI to help them organize client work more efficiently (49%).

By 2030, bankers also see a growing role of AI with respect to deal origination (24%). They look to better identify hidden cross-selling opportunities and improve win rates by analyzing client behavior and market signals.

> "As manual processes became automated, treasurers gained more time to focus on strategic matters. This shift has made the advisory role of relationship managers more important than ever."
>
> **Jay Davenport,** Co-Head of Global Corporate Sales, Bank of America

Figure 9

Efficiency is the most common goal for bankers' AI adoption



Operational efficiency

Current investments also reflect an orientation toward streamlined support tools such as chatbots and AI-powered intelligent assistants (36%), as well as more digital client onboarding (26%). Roughly 68% of bankers also report they already offer digital platforms covering most services (11%) or selected offerings (57%) to capture client flows while achieving more streamlined operations (see Figure 7).

While these investments improve day-to-day tasks, they remain relatively incremental. More must be done to fully address clients' demand for embedded finance solutions that integrate directly into ERP systems and automate financing decisions within procurement and sales workflows. Bankers are not unaware. They recognize a gap in integrating with client operations for embedded finance as the top priority to be addressed (56%).

Tokenization stands out as the next opportunity where banks can find greater efficiency.

Many institutions are looking at payments and settlement reconciliation (48%) as well as trade finance documentation (47%). These are areas where tokenization can reduce manual processing, accelerate settlement, and improve transparency across multi-party transactions.

Interestingly, more than 70% of bankers recognize the importance of unifying ownership of AI and tokenization initiatives to unlock strategic value. Unified governance can help to deliver real-time, programmable solutions to corporate CFOs. Essentially, AI and tokenization should not be viewed as separate technological advancements. When thoughtfully designed and implemented, they are complementary capabilities that banks can integrate to strengthen relationships with corporate clients (see Perspective, "How tokenization fuels agentic AI").

"We are seeing a clear evolution from traditional treasury operations to real-time treasury—and now to AI-powered treasury."

Ashutosh Kumar, Managing Director and Head of Transaction Banking for Asia-Pacific, Mizuho

Perspective

How tokenization fuels agentic AI

Tokenization of corporate assets—receivables, invoices, trade instruments, and supply-chain flows—provides the essential fuel for AI agents. It strips bureaucracy from treasury operations, accelerates settlement, and gives CFOs programmable, real-time access to liquidity and risk data, redefining corporate finance.

Trade finance remains process-heavy. A single transaction can span more than 20 steps across exporters, importers, forwarders, insurers, banks, and regulators, each generating its own documents and compliance checks. Letters of credit alone demand precise matching of bills of lading, invoices, certificates, and insurance papers. Minor discrepancies trigger manual reviews, delay payment, and raise working-capital costs.

Pairing agentic AI and tokenization changes the equation. Unlike task-level automation, agents can orchestrate the entire chain: request documents, verify compliance against live regulations, flag discrepancies early, confirm shipment status, and release financing on verified milestones—all with minimal human intervention. Processing times shrink from days to hours, errors fall, and clients gain continuous visibility. Yet for agentic AI to perform at its best, it relies on tokenization: once data such as permissions and identities is tokenized, agents can operate without repeatedly accessing the underlying information, thereby avoiding the latency and process costs that raw data handling would otherwise create.

Agentic AI and tokenization are converging rapidly. Agents pay and are paid in tokenized money. An agent that transacts needs settlement that is continuous, final on execution, and programmable. A bank that pairs agentic orchestration with a bank-issued deposit token keeps both the intelligence layer and the settlement balance. Yet in trade and supply chain finance, how a bank authorizes an agent to act is a critical question—which agent, under whose mandate, within what limits, and how that authority is revoked. This is, in effect, know-your-customer for non human actors.

Beyond efficiency, agents enable proactive risk management. They can continuously scan port congestion, currency controls, and geopolitical signals, then recalculate exposure, surface recommendations, or execute pre-approved mitigations. The result is 24/7, systematic support rather than reactive service.

For banks, the implication is strategic: agentic AI does not merely optimize existing operations. It positions the bank as the intelligent, risk-aware orchestration layer across the client's entire trade ecosystem.

Pairing agentic AI and tokenization changes the equation.

Risk, compliance, and governance

In risk and compliance, banks are actively deploying AI for anti-money-laundering and know-your-customer activities (30%), as well as fraud detection (30%).

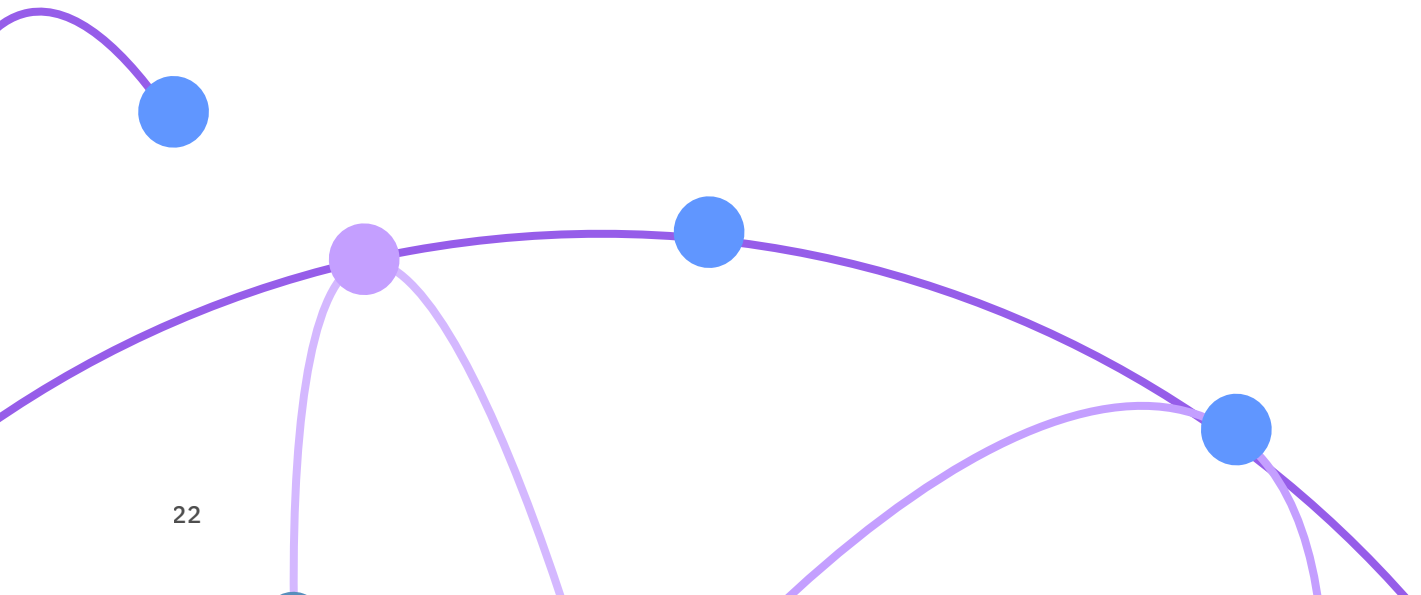
Importantly, around 51% of bankers also recognize that tokenization can enhance regulatory and tax reporting, as well as collateral management (49%). Tokenizing bank-corporate interactions enables proactive risk management by allowing the rebalancing of collateralized exposures in real time.

Smart contracts allow AI agents to automate complex treasury tasks—from working capital optimization to cross-border payments—by leveraging built-in audit trails that satisfy regulatory requirements.

Embedding cryptographic protections directly into these agentic AI operations on distributed ledgers enhances security. This integration also accelerates secured agentic e-commerce, enabling programmable agent-to-agent interactions among corporate clients, supply chain lower tiers, and their banking partners.

> "The more intelligence accumulates, the more seamlessly interactions can be integrated with broader banking services—turning isolated interactions into proactive, relationship-wide management."

Kartik Kaushik, Managing Director, RBC Clear and CEO New Business, Royal Bank of Canada



The platform opportunity in trade and supply chain finance

Overall, current technology investments of corporate bankers show encouraging alignment to client needs. But there is an apparent gap between those investments and transformative opportunity now at hand with respect to corporate client services. Specifically, banks' relatively low emphasis on tech-led innovation for revenue generation suggests many banks are playing catch-up rather than leading. Corporate clients are also expected to accelerate their own investments in AI for more self-directed orchestration of financial needs, as well as cash flow forecasting and tokenization of their supply chain activities.

The critical question remains: will banks' current roadmaps be sufficient to meet fast-changing client demands?

As bank transactions—such as a loan, a guarantee, or a payment—evolve into continuous, software-delivered orchestration, the source of value shifts. It moves away from the individual transaction itself toward the ongoing intelligence, automation, and insights that surround it.

By embedding AI-delivered services directly into the client's operational workflow, banks can shift competition away from the price of the underlying financial instrument toward the value of an integrated operational capability. This would be costly and disruptive for the client to replicate or replace.

The time to evolve is now because there is a powerful network effect dimension to this model. These AI-delivered trade and supply chain finance services become more valuable as more participants—buyers, suppliers, logistics providers, insurers, regulators—connect to the platform.

Early players amass proprietary data on trade flows, counterparty behavior, document patterns, and risk profiles—an advantage later entrants cannot easily replicate. This data edge compounds over time, continuously sharpening AI risk assessments, advisory recommendations, and automated processing.

In this sense, the AI-driven platform model in trade finance is not merely an incremental revenue opportunity. It is a structural moat that, if built deliberately and at scale, can redefine the competitive hierarchy in corporate and transaction banking over the coming decade.

Perspective

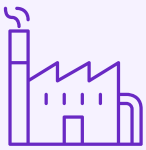
Sector-specific needs and opportunities

Industries face distinct pressures that are reshaping how companies manage working capital and risk. In response, firms are moving toward more flexible, structured, and digitally enabled financing models that prioritize real-time visibility and automated execution. Here is a dive into automotive, manufacturing, consumer products, telecom, and energy.



Automotive

As auto companies navigate the EV transition and supply chain challenges, they are shifting toward flexible financing that adapts to changing inventory values. Our research suggests that customer discounts to accelerate payments and inventory optimization has been the industry's primary method to free up liquidity. Banks can build or integrate advanced digital monitoring platforms that connect directly to clients' ERP and inventory systems for real-time valuation updates and automated borrowing-base adjustments.



Manufacturing

Manufacturers are accelerating the transition from open-account terms to structured trade finance arrangements. The new approach ring-fences specific shipments and ties funding directly to electronic inventory control, protecting against tariffs and raw-material cost spikes. Our research finds that manufacturers' have directed their attention to increased digital efficiency of supply chain operations to navigate market complexity. Banks can orchestrate platforms capable of managing electronic warehouse receipts, real-time collateral tracking, and automated release of funds upon verified end-buyer payment.

"Corporate bankers are moving away from a traditional model centered on lending transactions toward a more proactive, advisory-driven approach."

Tawatchai Cheevanon, Chief Product & Business Solutions Officer, Krungthai Bank



Consumer products

Squeezed by margin compression and demand swings, consumer firms are prioritizing automated early-payment solutions, anchoring on the credit strength of major buyers, rather than their own weaker balance sheets. Banks can deliver scalable, API-enabled platforms that provide greater automation and full visibility across the buyer-supplier ecosystem.



Telecommunications

Facing both significant infrastructure investment and pressure to improve returns, telecom firms are focused on capital discipline. In our research, they identify gaining greater visibility of cash flow across their supply chain as the top priority. Banks can develop robust digital syndication and portfolio management platforms that enable efficient risk distribution across multiple lenders and provide automated covenant monitoring and seamless integration with clients' treasury systems for hedging execution.



Energy

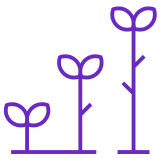
With geopolitical complexity, pricing volatility, and intensified capital demands for the energy transition, most CFOs and treasurers in the energy and resources sector are seeking to optimize earned yield and gain greater visibility of cash flow generation across their supply chain. Banks can deliver specialized digital platforms that support multi-bank coordination, real-time hedging, automated sanctions screening, and sustainability data integration to structure and monitor increasingly complex financing arrangements.

Action guide

Meet the moment

Corporate bankers in trade and supply-chain finance must meet rising client expectations through technology and business model innovation. AI, tokenization, and platform orchestration can turn fragmented processes into high-value client engagement across their business lifecycle.

The application of industry standards becomes critical not just to evolve banking architectures but to redesign business processes with speed and clarity. Coordinated change across four areas—revenue, operations, risk, and talent—is essential.



Revenue and growth

Banking clients increasingly seek greater flexibility and autonomy in how they access financial services through AI enablement and integrated platforms.

What to do:

- Map business journeys and capabilities to identify where value can be unlocked through agentic AI and digital platforms—while overlaying the existing application estate to identify redundancies and simplify.
- Connect deep-tier suppliers and large corporates through tokenized and interoperable multi-bank networks to deliver a unified proposition that combines financing, real-time insights, and operational excellence beyond what any institution can provide independently.
- Measure progress by share-of-wallet growth and client engagement with ancillary services—not transaction volume alone—as tokenization compresses transaction fees, erodes float-based economics, and puts deposit balances in play.
- Establish your money strategy explicitly, not by default. Decide whether the bank issues a deposit token, distributes a third-party stablecoin, or both—and price the funding consequence of each before client demands make the choice for you.



Operational efficiency

Efficiency doesn't only reduce waste. It enables operating model evolution by reducing complexity and cost.

What to do:

- Drive step-change efficiency through agentic AI by embracing emerging standards such as Model Context Protocol (MCP) that enable seamless agent-to-agent interaction.
- Embed your capabilities directly into client ERP and treasury ecosystems to partner with your corporate clients to get ready for an agent-to-agent reality.
- Make tokenization the north star of your modernization roadmap to build resilient integration layers that connect fragmented legacy systems with trade and supply-chain ecosystems through an open architecture.



Risk and compliance

Established risk and compliance practices continue to be challenged by a volatile business environment, requiring near-real-time adjustment.

What to do:

- Intensify risk control from periodic reviews to a continuous and proactive assessment made of agentic AI oversight, tokenized documentation and programmability for early-detection and dynamic collateral management.
- Move from siloed risk and compliance controls across applications and businesses to a unified posture that spans across the organization.
- Establish a centralized ownership registry powered by AI-driven entity resolution, continuous client monitoring, and real-time external intelligence.



Talent

The corporate banker's role is evolving across relationship management, risk oversight, and transactional banking.

What to do:

- Invest in skills to master tokenization principles and economics—including the balance-sheet difference between tokenized deposits and stablecoins—alongside digital asset compliance to advise corporate clients on new solutions that transform working capital, liquidity, and cross-border payments.
- Strengthen bankers and marketing executives with AI-native skills to help them influence how their propositions can be discovered in an agent-driven corporate world shaped by generative engine optimization (GEO).
- Engage bankers from the start of an AI transformation project, aligning everyone's incentives to mitigate friction as AI reshuffles the organization.

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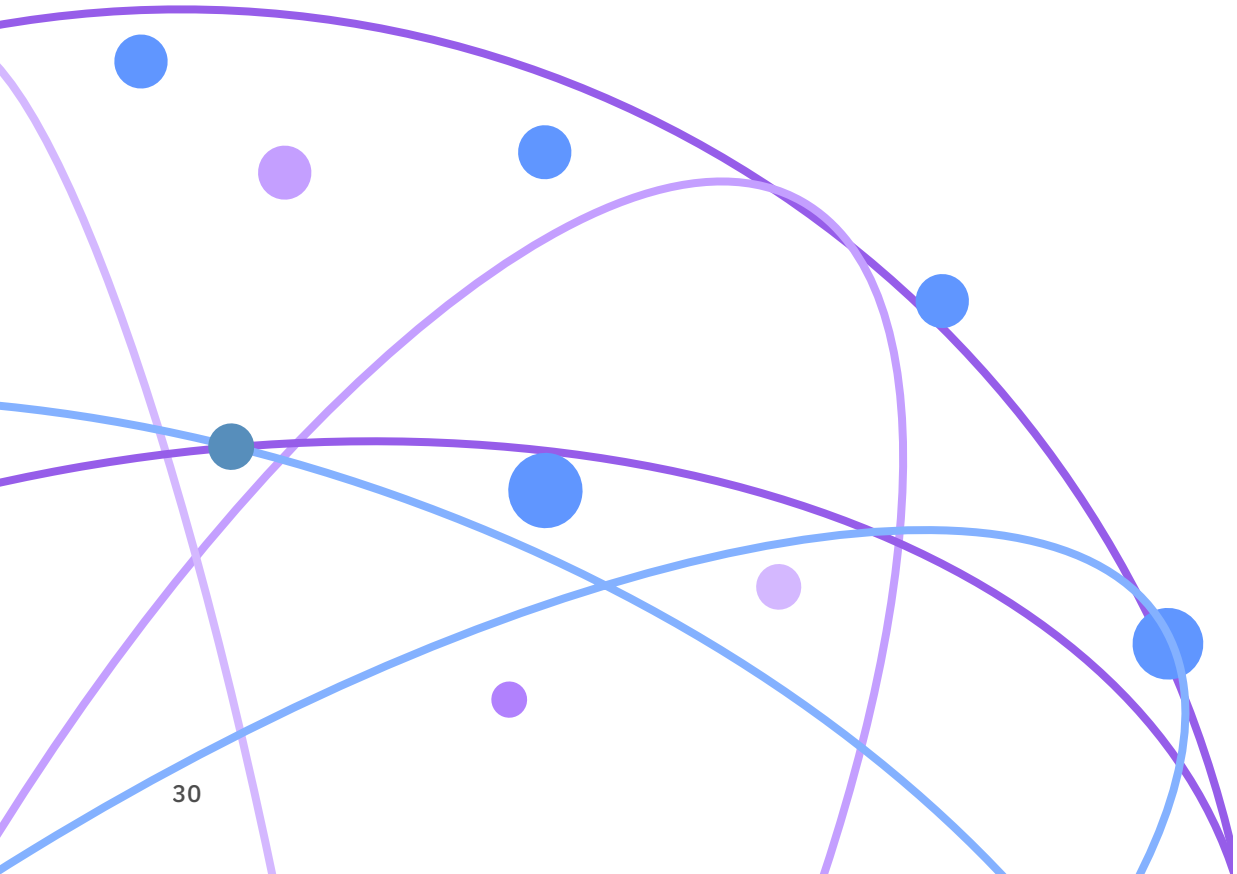
The IBM Institute for Business Value (IBV), in cooperation with Oxford Economics, conducted two complementary global surveys in June and July 2026 to examine the future of corporate banking, treasury and trade services, liquidity management, AI adoption, and tokenization. The research was designed to capture perspectives from both corporate banking providers and the organizations they serve, enabling analysis across the broader corporate banking ecosystem.

The first survey gathered responses from 250 senior corporate banking executives representing banks with assets exceeding US$10 billion. Respondents included leaders responsible for corporate banking, trade finance, supply chain finance, cash management, and lending. Fieldwork was conducted across 29 markets spanning North America, Latin America, Europe, the Middle East and Africa, and Asia-Pacific.

The second survey targeted 500 CFOs and senior finance leaders from organizations that use corporate banking services across multiple industries, including consumer products, manufacturing, automotive, telecommunications, and energy and resources.

Analysis incorporated descriptive statistics and cross-tabulation tables to identify patterns across regions, organizational characteristics, performance indicators, and strategic priorities. Findings were analyzed separately for banking executives and corporate banking clients, and compared where appropriate to identify areas of alignment and divergence between banks and their customers.

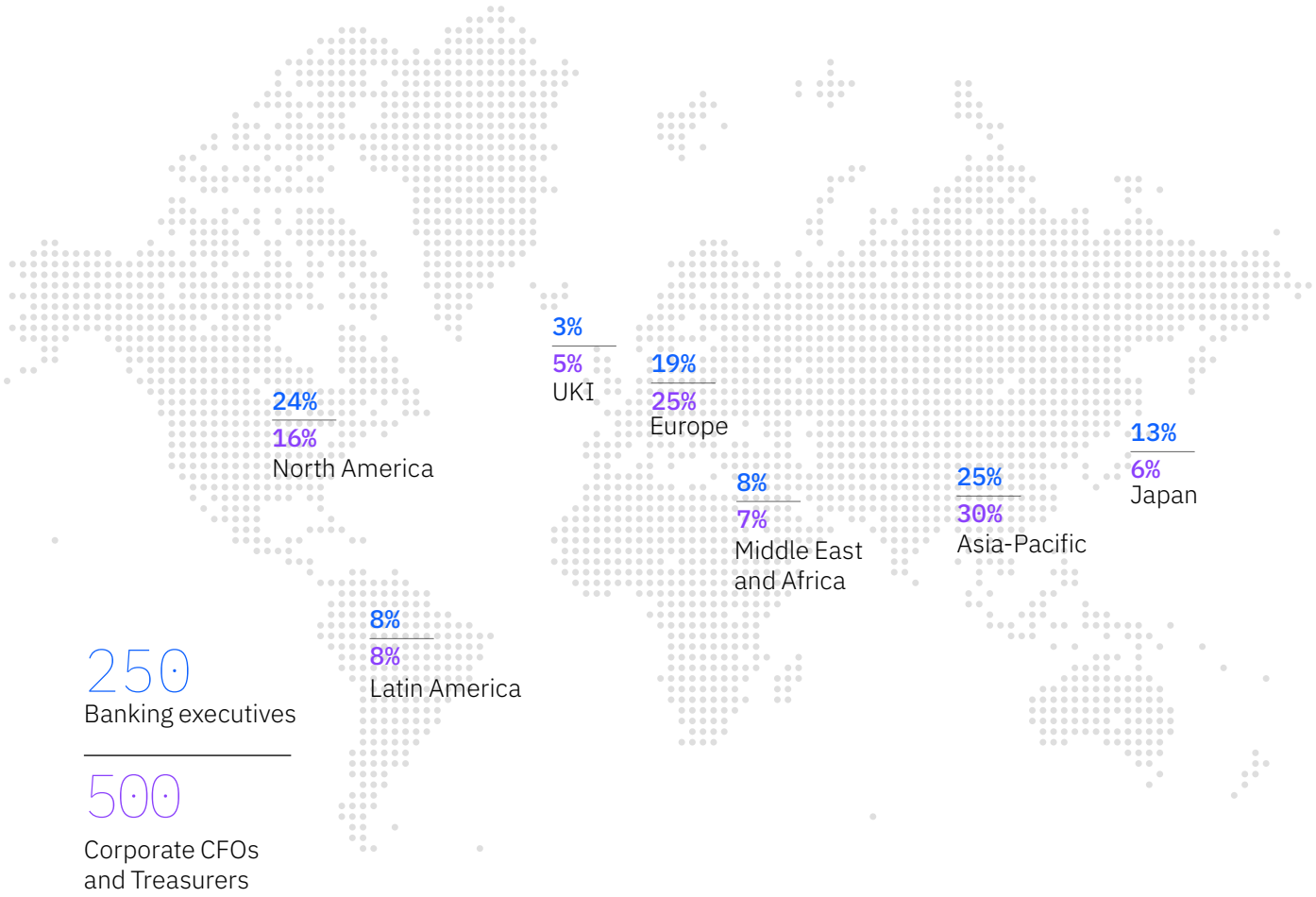
Several survey questions required respondents to rank competing capabilities, priorities, risks, and strategic actions. These data were analyzed using a Plackett-Luce model, which

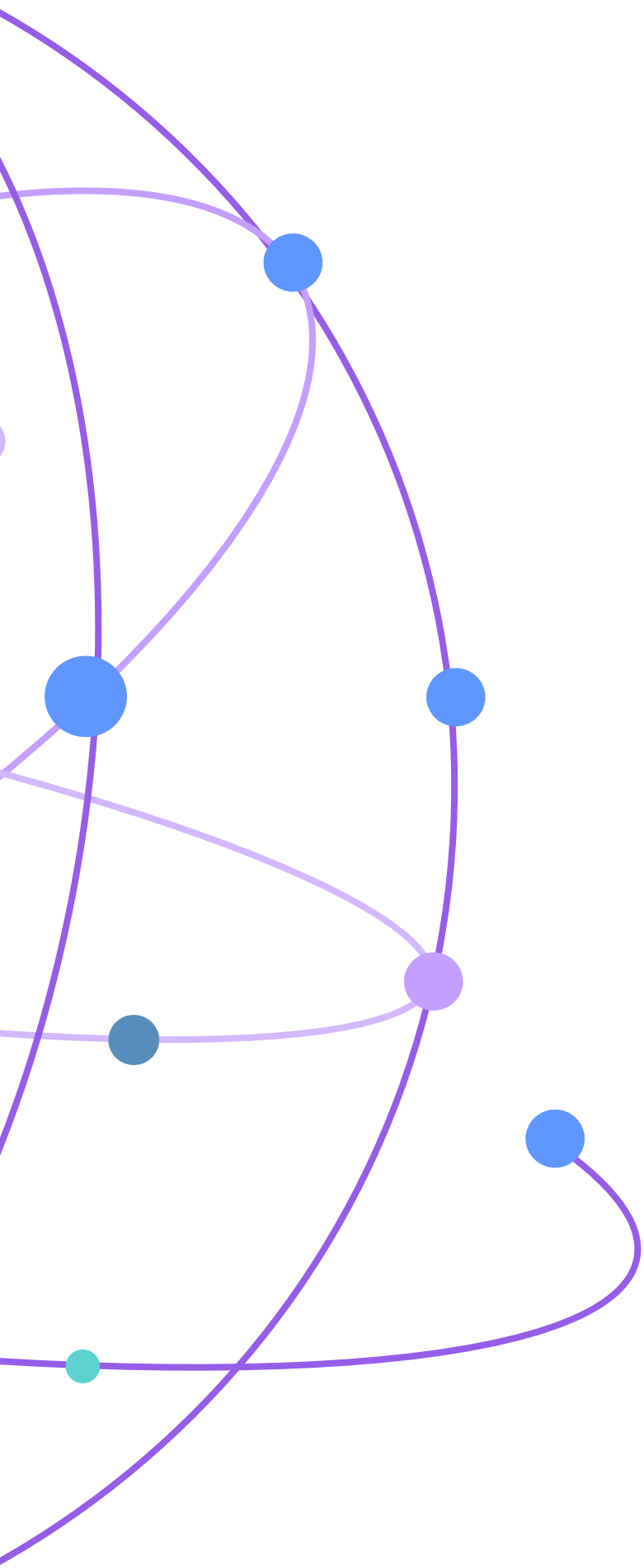


estimates the relative strength of preference for each item based on its position within respondents' rankings. Unlike simple average-rank approaches, the Plackett-Luce method accounts for the sequential nature of ranked choices and accommodates variation in ranking patterns across respondents.

Results are reported as preference probabilities, which represent an item's relative importance within a given set of alternatives. Higher probabilities indicate stronger preference but should be interpreted relative to the other items evaluated within the same ranking exercise rather than as percentages of respondents. Confidence intervals were calculated to assess the precision and stability of model estimates. Where intervals overlap, small differences in estimated probabilities should not necessarily be interpreted as meaningful differences in preference.

The Plackett-Luce methodology informed the ranking-based findings presented throughout the report, providing insight into factors influencing corporate bank selection, sources of value in treasury and trade services, responses to tariff uncertainty, working-capital and liquidity priorities, and barriers to banking transformation.





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How BIAN can help

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How BAFT can help

With more than 300 institutional members across over 60 countries, BAFT is the leading global association for transaction banking. BAFT helps its members navigate evolving challenges in trade, payments, compliance, and emerging technologies through advocacy, thought leadership, education, and global forums. By connecting members with peers, regulators, and industry partners worldwide, BAFT provides industry expertise, practical resources, and opportunities to collaborate, share best practices, build capabilities, and help shape the future of the transaction banking industry.

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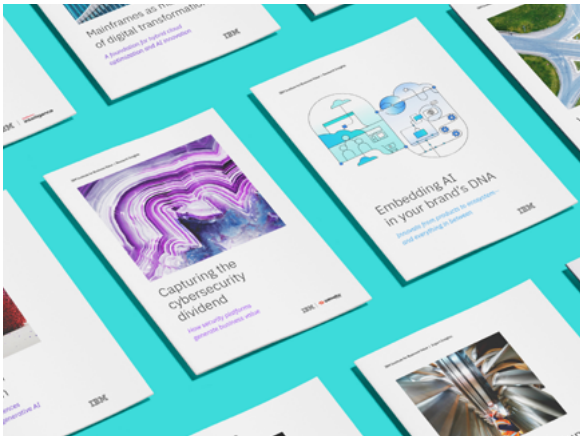
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Notes and sources

1. The eight executives are quoted in this report. Complete interviews with each are published in the compendium *2026 Voice of the Makers: Corporate banking beyond the transaction.* (IBM Institute for Business Value, forthcoming October 2026.)

2. *2026 Global Outlook for Banking and Financial Markets: Banking in the tokenized economy.* IBM Institute for Business Value. March 2026. ibm.biz/2026-gobfm



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